

SCALING A SERVICE BUSINESS WITH AI

The part the story leaves out. Six diagnostics for founders who are still the thing everything queues behind.

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THIS IS NOT A SUMMARY OF THE ARTICLE

I wrote about the decade I spent building a service business and trying to stop being its bottleneck. That piece ends at what to do about it and then stops, because that part is not a story. It is work.

This is the work. Six diagnostics, in the order that matters. None of them are clever. All of them are things I got wrong for years before getting right.

Set aside an hour and write in it. A diagnostic you answer in your head is a diagnostic you will flatter yourself through. The value here is entirely in the honesty of your own answers, which is an annoying thing for a document to depend on but there it is.

What you will have at the end

A named constraint, a re-sorted list of what actually needs a person, and a first ninety days that does not start with buying software.

THE BOTTLENECK HAS YOUR NAME ON IT

Every service business has one constraint that everything else queues behind. In most of them it is a person, and in most of those it is the founder. This is not a character flaw. It is what happens when a business grows out of one person being good at something.

The test is not how busy you are. Busy is easy to mistake for essential. The test is **what stops when you stop.**

WRITE THIS ONE DOWN

List every decision from the past week that could not have happened without you. Beside each, mark which of the three it was.

C only you had the context **A** only you had the authority **S** only you had the skill

Now count them. Context can be written down, and usually in an afternoon. Authority can be handed over, and the fear of doing so is almost always larger than the cost of it. Skill is the only one that needs hiring or training.

Most founders find their list is overwhelmingly context. It is the cheapest of the three to fix and the one nobody fixes, because writing things down feels like it is not the job.

RE-SORT EVERY RECURRING TASK

Take the recurring work of the business and put each piece in exactly one of three buckets. Not where it sits today. Where it belongs now.

01

Only you

Judgement, relationships, taste, and the calls that carry real consequence. This bucket is smaller than your calendar implies.

02

Anyone trained

Process with a right answer. If you can describe how it should go, it does not need you, it needs writing down once.

03

Software, now

Pattern work over data you already hold. Drafting, summarising, sorting, checking, first passes of almost anything.

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The trap

Bucket three grew enormously in two years. Almost nobody re-sorted. A list made in 2023 is now wrong.

THE ONLY QUESTION THAT MATTERS HERE

Which tasks did you put in bucket one purely because you have always done them, and not because they genuinely need your judgement? Name three.

WHAT ACTUALLY CHANGED, AND WHAT DID NOT

The useful framing is narrow. Something specific changed, and a great deal did not, and most disappointment comes from confusing the two.

What changed

The cost of a competent first draft fell to roughly nothing. Every process that begins with one, and most do, now starts much further along. Proposals, research, reports, job specifications, code scaffolding, meeting notes, first replies.

What did not change

Someone still has to decide the draft is right. That someone is a person, and they need to be good, and they need enough context to know when the confident answer in front of them is wrong. Removing that person is how organisations produce enormous volumes of plausible nonsense at speed.

BE SPECIFIC

Name one process in your business that starts with a first draft and still takes a person more than an hour. That is your first candidate, not the thing you saw in a demo.

THE ORDER IS THE WHOLE THING

Almost every failed attempt I have seen, including two of mine, failed on sequence rather than technology.

01 Write down how the work actually happens

Including the workarounds nobody admits to in a meeting. This is the step everyone skips and it is the step that decides the outcome.

02 Get the data into one clean place

One version of each client, each project, each number. Software cannot act on what it cannot see, and it cannot see across four spreadsheets.

03 Build the system people actually work in

Shaped around how the team already operates, not a template you bend the business into.

04 Only now, automate

At this point it is close to easy, which is the tell that the first three steps were the real work.

Start at step four and you get the pilot that demos beautifully and changes nothing. That is not a technology failure. It is a sequencing one, and it is expensive because it also teaches everyone that this does not work.

LOCATE YOURSELF

Which of the four steps is your business actually on right now, for the process you most want to fix? Write the step number and one sentence on why you are certain.

WHEN WORD OF MOUTH RUNS OUT

Referral is not a growth channel. It is a ceiling with good manners. It arrives when it arrives, it reflects work you did nine months ago, and you cannot turn it up in the quarter you need it.

For years I read a full pipeline as evidence that the business was healthy. It was evidence that the last two years had gone well, which is a different and much less useful fact.

COUNT THEM HONESTLY

Where did your last ten clients come from? Write the actual source, not the category you would put in a deck.

If eight or more are referral, you do not have a growth problem yet. You have a growth risk, which is worse, because it stays invisible right up until the quarter it is not.

CULTURE IS WHAT CARRIES ALL OF IT

This is the one that sounds soft and is not. Every system described here is executed by people who either care about the outcome or do not, and no process survives contact with a team that does not.

There is a specific new problem. If software now does the work juniors used to do, the path that produced your seniors is gone. The people who learned judgement by doing a thousand small things badly and then better will not learn it that way again.

What this means in practice

You hire for judgement earlier than you used to, you pay for it, and you accept a smaller team of better people rather than a larger one of cheaper ones. The economics now work in that direction anyway, which is convenient, because it is also the only version that produces work you would put your name on.

THE UNCOMFORTABLE ONE

If your best person left tomorrow, how much of what they know exists anywhere other than in their head?

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Nothing here requires buying anything, which is deliberate. The buying decision gets much easier once these are done, and much cheaper.

01 **Weeks one and two**

Complete diagnostics one and two, in writing. Do not skip the writing. You are looking for the tasks in bucket one that do not deserve to be there.

02 **Weeks three to six**

Take the single largest context item from diagnostic one and write it down properly, once, so somebody else can act on it. Then hand it over and resist taking it back the first time it is done differently to how you would.

03 **Weeks seven to ten**

Pick one process from diagnostic three. Map it, clean whatever data it depends on, and only then look at tools. Expect the cleaning to take longer than the building, because it will.

04 **Weeks eleven and twelve**

Build one source of new work that is not referral. One. Chosen because you can sustain it, not because it is fashionable.

Ninety days of this beats two years of pilots, and I say that as somebody who ran the two years of pilots first.

IF YOU GET STUCK ON ONE OF THESE

The diagnostics are the easy part to publish and the hard part to sit with. If you work through them and hit something you cannot get past, write to me and tell me which one. I read everything.

The full article

engjellrraklli.com/journal

Everything else I write

engjellrraklli.com